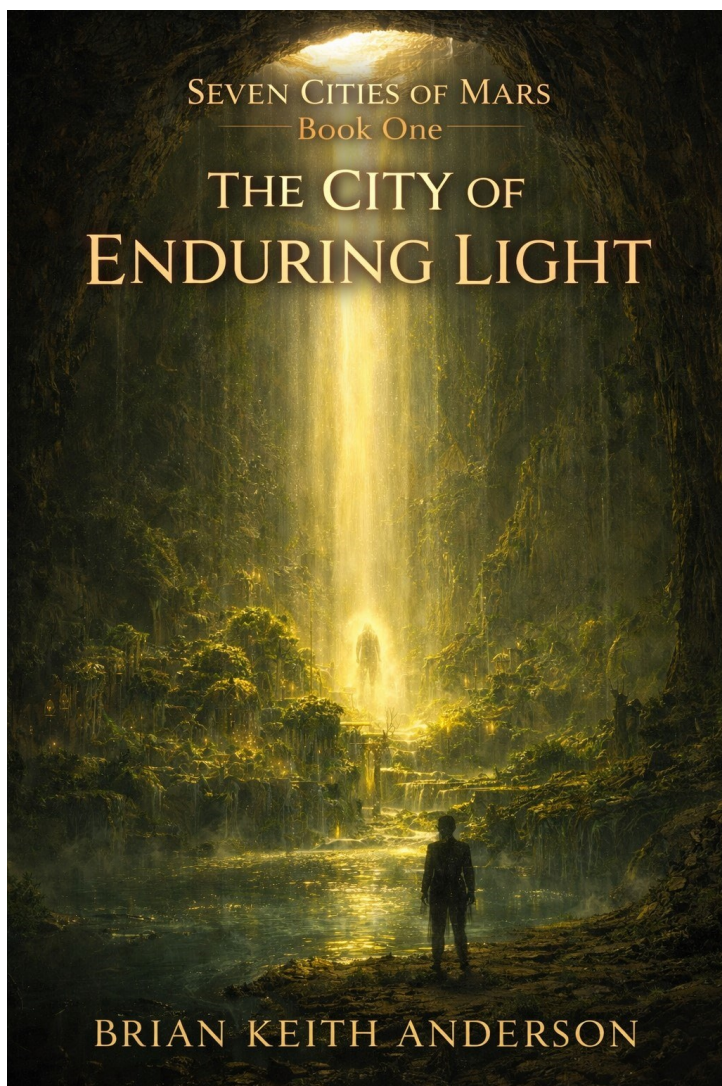




The City of Enduring Light

Book One of the Seven Cities of Mars

by

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Dedication

For those who endured
when the world asked them to break—
and chose instead
to remain.

The Seven Bogs of Mars

Series

- The Seven Bogs of Mars
- The Bog of Patience
- The Bog of Silence
- The Bog of Movement
- The Bog of Restraint
- The Bog of Passage
- The Bog of Interconnection
- The Bog of the Seventh Heart

The Seven Cities of Mars

Series

- The City of Enduring Light
- The City of Silence
- The City of Flowing Currents
- The City of Restraint
- The City of Passage
- The City of Interconnection
- The City of the Seventh Heart

Epigraph

This was not the beginning of the cities—
but the moment they are remembered.

Preface

“What is restored does not return as it
was—

it returns as what it has become through
endurance.”

You may not remember when the first
city fell.

Most do not.

Time has a way of softening what once
seemed permanent.

Of quieting what once stood in brilliance.

But the cities were not lost.

They were placed into silence.

Not as punishment—

but as preservation.

Now, something has begun again.

Not in force.

Not in command.

But in patience.

You will not be told what to see.

You will not be shown what to believe.

You will walk.

And in walking—

you may remember.

Because the Cities have never forgotten.

Chapter One

Where Endurance

Remains

The light did not arrive all at once.

It gathered.

Slowly—

as though the world itself was

remembering how to breathe.

Asa stood at the edge of the stone rise,

silent. Below him, the land stretched in

muted tones of rust and shadow, the

surface of Mars still carrying the quiet
weight of what had been lost. The Bog
behind him pulsed with a soft, living
hum—the steady presence of life
returned, but not yet complete.

The bees moved in gentle arcs around
him.

Not hurried.

Not searching.

Knowing.

He had come to recognize that
movement. It was not direction.

It was belonging.

He rested his hand lightly against the worn stone beside him. It was smooth in places, though no wind should have shaped it so. Time had touched this place differently.

Or something else had.

Ahead, just beyond the rise, something caught the light.

Not a reflection.

Not a trick of shadow.

A presence.

He narrowed his eyes slightly, adjusting
not to see clearer—but to feel.

There.

A line.

Faint at first.

Then—

Defined.

A seam in the world.

It did not glow.

It endured.

The stone beneath it carried a quiet strength, darker than the surrounding terrain, as if it had held its form through ages that had worn everything else away.

It did not call to him.

It did not need to.

Asa exhaled slowly.

“This is where it begins,” he said, though no one had asked.

The bees shifted. Not toward the line—
but toward him.

As though waiting.

He stepped forward.

The ground did not resist.

But it did not welcome him either.

It acknowledged.

Each step carried a subtle weight—not of gravity, but of presence, as though the land itself was aware of being crossed.

He reached the seam.

Up close, it was no longer a line.

It was a threshold.

No markings.

No symbols.

No opening.

Just a place where the world had once
been joined... and then closed.

He placed his hand against it.

The stone was warm.

Not with heat—

But with memory.

For a moment, nothing happened. Then—

Deep beneath the surface—

Something listened.

The hum from the Bog behind him
shifted, almost imperceptibly. The bees
grew still in the air, hovering—not
frozen, but attentive.

Waiting.

Asa did not move.

He did not press.

He did not ask.

He simply remained.

And in that stillness—

the first answer came.

The stone did not open.

It did not change.

But it knew him.

And somewhere far below—

something that had endured

began

to wake.

He did not pull his hand away.

“Thank you for reading this sample”